

Taskwarrior Nautical v5.6 - Quick Start & Cheat Sheet

Use `cp` when the next task depends on completion time. Use `anchor` when it must land on a calendar date. Complete the current task normally; Nautical creates the next link.

For installation details and deeper operational guidance, use the [Systems Manual](#).

1. Start in Five Minutes

Install

```
# Install the three hooks.
mkdir -p ~/.task/hooks
cd ~/.task/hooks
curl -LO https://github.com/catanadj/taskwarrior-nautical/raw/main/on-
{add,modify,exit}.nautical
chmod +x on-*.nautical

# Install the shared package beside the Taskwarrior hooks directory.
cd ..
curl -L https://github.com/catanadj/taskwarrior-nautical/archive/refs/heads/main.tar.gz \
| tar -xz --strip-components=1 taskwarrior-nautical-main/nautical_core

# Register Nautical's Taskwarrior UDAs.
curl -s https://raw.githubusercontent.com/catanadj/taskwarrior-nautical/main/uda.conf >>
~/.taskrc

# Optional: richer panels.
python3 -m pip install rich
```

Create the first chains

```
# Next task is due 3 days after this one is completed.
task add "Follow up" cp:3d due:tomorrow+9h

# First task lands on the next Monday or Friday; Nautical assigns its due date.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,fri"

# Complete a task normally; Nautical creates its next link.
task +LATEST done
```

If `due` is omitted from an anchor task, Nautical assigns the first matching date automatically.

Optional command helper

From a full repository checkout:

```
mkdir -p ~/.local/bin
ln -s "$PWD/nautical" ~/.local/bin/nautical
nautical doctor
```

2. Pick the Recurrence Engine

Need	Use	Example
Delay from completion	<code>cp</code>	<code>cp:3d</code>
Calendar schedule	<code>anchor</code>	<code>anchor:"w:mon,fri"</code>
Explicit dates from a file	<code>anchor_file</code>	<code>anchor_file:"events.csv"</code>
Remove calendar dates	<code>omit</code> / <code>omit_file</code>	<code>omit:"y:12-25"</code>

Use `cp` or `anchor` recurrence on one task, not both.

3. Completion-Period Chains (`cp`)

```
cp:3d          # 3 days after completion
cp:8h          # 8 hours after completion
cp:"3d,7d,14d"  # repeat a sequence: 3d, then 7d, then 14d
cp:"rand(3d..7d)" # deterministic pick between 3 and 7 days per link
cp:"14d~2d"     # deterministic pick between 12 and 16 days
cp:24h+1s      # exact addition instead of preserving wall-clock time
```

```
# Fixed maintenance interval.
task add "Mow lawn" cp:12d due:tomorrow+9h

# Exact sub-day interval.
task add "Take vitamin" cp:8h due:today+15h

# Repeating treatment sequence.
task add "Insect treatment" cp:"3d,20d,7d,10d,3d" due:today

# Loosely fortnightly inspection.
task add "Routine inspection" cp:"14d~2d" due:today

# Bounded random delay.
task add "Check trap" cp:"rand(3d..7d)" due:today
```

Day-based periods preserve the task's wall-clock due time. Sub-day periods use exact time. Random choices are reproducible per `chainID`, but different chains get independent sequences.

4. Anchor Grammar

```
w:mon,fri          # comma: either Monday or Friday in one atom
w:mon + y:apr      # plus: Monday that is also in April
w:mon | y:04-12    # pipe: any Monday or April 12
(w:mon | m:last-fri)@t=09:00 # parentheses: group before applying one modifier
w/2:mon           # /N: every second eligible weekly period
moon:full         # next local date nearest full moon
w:fri@moon=full   # Friday filtered to full-moon dates
(moon:full + w:fri)@t=20:00 # full moon and Friday at 20:00
```

Moon anchors require optional `astral` and an explicit timezone in `[astronomy.locations.<name>]`. Supported phases are `new`, `first-quarter`, `full`, and `last-quarter`; aliases such as `full-moon` are accepted. Missing support is reported as an error; Nautical never invents a fallback date.

`+` binds more tightly than `|`. Quote expressions containing spaces, `+`, `|`, or parentheses:

```
task add "April workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri + y:apr"
```

5. Weekly Anchors (`w:`)

```
w:mon              # every Monday
w:mon,fri          # every Monday and Friday
w:mon..fri         # every weekday, Monday through Friday
w:fri..mon         # Friday through Monday, wrapping across the week
w:wk               # weekdays (alias)
w:wd               # weekdays (alias)
w:we               # weekend days
w/2:mon            # Monday every second ISO week
w:rand             # one random day in each ISO week
w:2rand            # two distinct random days in each ISO week
```

```
# Monday and Friday workout.
task add "Gym" anchor:"w:mon,fri" due:today+9h

# Monday through Wednesday study block.
task add "Study" anchor:"w:mon..wed"

# Different time on each weekday.
task add "Split training" anchor:"w:mon@t=09:00,fri@t=15:00"

# Two random business days each week.
task add "Field inspection" anchor:"w:2rand@bd@t=09:00"
```

6. Monthly Anchors (`m:`)

Calendar and business days

m:1	# first calendar day of each month
m:15	# 15th calendar day of each month
m:-1	# last calendar day of each month
m:ld	# last calendar day (alias)
m:1,15,-1	# first, 15th, and last calendar day
m:1..7	# every date from the 1st through the 7th
m:5bd	# 5th business day of each month
m:-1bd	# last business day of each month
m:lbd	# last business day (alias)
m/2:-1	# last day of every second eligible month
m:rand	# one random date each month
m:3rand	# three distinct random dates each month

Weekday positions

m:2sat	# second Saturday of each month
m:last-fri	# last Friday of each month
m:1wed,3fri	# first Wednesday and third Friday
m/2:2sat	# second Saturday of every second eligible month

```
# First and last day of each month.
task add "Billing sweep" anchor:"m:1,-1" anchor_mode:all due:today

# First day, rolled to the next business day at 09:00.
task add "Payroll" anchor:"m:1@nbd@t=09:00" anchor_mode:all due:today

# Last Friday of each month.
task add "Design session" anchor:"m:last-fri"

# Three random weekdays each month.
task add "Monthly sampling" anchor:"m:3rand + w:mon..fri"
```

7. Yearly Anchors (y:)

Fixed yearly dates use MM-DD.

y:05-20	# every May 20
y:01-15,04-15,07-15,10-15	# January, April, July, and October 15
y:04-20..05-15	# every date from April 20 through May 15
y:apr	# every date in April
y:rand	# one random date each year
y:2rand	# two distinct random dates each year
y:10-rand	# one random date in October
y:02-29	# leap day; years without it are skipped
y:d100	# 100th calendar day of each year
y:d-1	# last calendar day of each year
y:d100..d110	# calendar days 100 through 110
y:w20	# all seven days of ISO week 20
y:w-1	# all days of the final ISO week
y:w20 + w:mon	# Monday of ISO week 20
y:w-1 + w:fri	# Friday of the final ISO week
y:q1	# every date in the first quarter

y:q1s	# every date in January, Q1's start month
y:q1m	# every date in February, Q1's middle month
y:q1e	# every date in March, Q1's end month
y/2:w1	# ISO week 1 every second eligible ISO year

Year-day and ISO-week ranges repeat the prefix on both ends: `d100..d110` and `w10..w13`. Negative values count from the end. A nonexistent day 366 or ISO week 53 contributes no date for that year.

```
# Fixed anniversary.
task add "Anniversary" anchor:"y:05-20" anchor_mode:all due:today

# Two random dates selected only from April, July, or October.
task add "Seasonal audits" anchor:"y:2rand + y:apr,jul,oct"

# Last calendar day at 17:00.
task add "Year-end archive" anchor:"y:d-1@t=17:00"

# Friday of the final ISO week.
task add "ISO year close" anchor:"y:w-1 + w:fri"
```

8. Seasonal Anchors

Seasonal selectors use fixed calendar windows and the same positional syntax as week, month, quarter, and year selectors:

@in-spring	# Mar 1 through May 31
@in-summer	# Jun 1 through Aug 31
@in-autumn	# Sep 1 through Nov 30
@in-winter	# Dec 1 through Feb 28/29

```
# First and last Monday of each spring.
task add "Spring planning" anchor:"(w:mon)@in-spring=first,last"

# Last Friday of each winter at 09:00.
task add "Winter review" anchor:"(w:fri)@in-winter=last@t=09:00"

# First weekday of summer, then one business day later.
task add "Summer handoff" anchor:"(w:mon..fri)@in-summer=first@+1bd"
```

The candidate must be parenthesized. Nautical selects the position inside the season first, then applies modifiers. Winter crosses the year boundary: winter 2026 starts on December 1, 2026 and ends on February 28, 2027.

9. Positional Selection

Select a date by its position among all candidate matches in a period:

(w:mon w:wed w:fri)@in-week=last	# last M/W/F match in each week
(w:tue w:thu)@in-month=first,last	# first and last Tue/Thu each month
(w:mon)@in-quarter=last	# last Monday of each quarter
(w:mon)@in-year=10th	# tenth Monday of each year
(w:mon)@in-month=2nd-last	# second-to-last Monday each month
(w:mon)@in-quarter=last@+1bd	# select, then move one business day

Positions accept `first`, `last`, `3rd`, `2nd-last`, and comma-separated lists.

The candidate must be parenthesized and deterministic. Nautical rejects positions that can never exist and advises when a valid expression is redundant or boundary-sensitive.

```
# Last Monday, Wednesday, or Friday in each week.
task add "Weekly closeout" anchor:"(w:mon | w:wed | w:fri)@in-week=last"

# First and last Tuesday or Thursday in each month.
task add "Twice-monthly review" anchor:"(w:tue | w:thu)@in-month=first,last"

# Tenth Monday of each year at 09:00.
task add "Annual checkpoint" anchor:"(w:mon)@in-year=10th@t=09:00"
```

10. Modifiers

@t=09:00	# use 09:00 for the matched date
@t=09:00,17:30	# create occurrences at both times
@bd	# keep the match only when it is a business day
@nbd	# roll to the next business day
@pbd	# roll to the previous business day
@nw	# roll to the nearest weekday
@+2d	# move two calendar days forward
@-2d	# move two calendar days backward
@+2bd	# move two business days forward
@-2bd	# move two business days backward
@next-mon	# roll forward to the next Monday
@prev-fri	# roll backward to the previous Friday

Rolls run first, calendar-day offsets second, and business-day offsets last.

Without `bc`, a business day means Monday through Friday.

```
# Two business days before the rolled month end.
task add "Month-end preparation" anchor:"m:-1@pbd@-2bd"

# Shared time applied to either branch.
task add "Shared review" anchor:"(w:mon | m:last-fri)@t=09:00"

# Previous Friday before December 31.
task add "Year-end reminder" anchor:"y:12-31@prev-fri"
```

11. Omit Rules and Date Files

The final schedule is:

```
(anchor + anchor_file dates) - (omit + omit_file dates)
```

```
# Remove every Wednesday from a Monday/Wednesday/Friday schedule.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri" omit:"w:wed"

# Remove Wednesdays only during April, July, and October.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri" omit:"w:wed + y:apr,jul,oct"

# Remove a holiday window.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri" omit:"y:12-24..12-31"
```

Set trusted file directories in `config-nautical.toml`:

```
anchor_file_dir = "/home/user/.task/nautical_anchors"
omit_file_dir = "/home/user/.task/nautical_omits"
```

Plain date file:

```
# One date
2026-01-01
# Inclusive date range
2026-04-20..2026-05-15
# comments are ignored
```

CSV file:

```
date,description
2026-01-01,New Year
2026-12-25,Christmas
```

```
# Use every date in a file.
task add "Company event" anchor_file:"events.csv"

# One day before each file date, at two times.
task add "Event prep" anchor_file:"events.csv@-1d@t=12:00,18:00"

# Weekly schedule excluding file-backed holidays.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri" omit_file:"holidays.csv"

# Use every CSV file in the configured directory.
task add "Calendar review" anchor_file:"*.*"
```

11. Named Business Calendars

Define a calendar in `config-nautical.toml`:

```
[business_calendar.work]
anchor = "w:mon..fri"
```

```
omit = ["y:01-01", "y:12-25"]
anchor_file = ["extra-open-days.csv"]
omit_file = ["holidays.csv", "company-closures-*.csv"]
```

Use it through the `bc` UDA:

```
# Last business day according to the work calendar.
task add "Submit payroll" anchor:"m:-1bd@t=16:00" bc:work
```

The selected calendar controls business-day ordinals, filters, rolls, and business-day offsets.

12. Modes, Limits, and Stops

```
anchor_mode:skip           # skip missed anchors; default for routines
anchor_mode:all            # create every missed anchor in order
anchor_mode:flex           # skip backlog once, then continue strictly
chainMax:6                 # stop after link 6
chainUntil:2027-12-31      # stop after this local date
chainUntil:2027-12-31T12:00 # stop after this local date and time
chain:off                  # disable recurrence manually
```

In `config-nautical.toml`, use `panel_mode = "live"` for a short line-by-line Rich reveal, `live_panel_duration_ms = 0` for no motion, or `panel_mode = "fast"` on slow terminals.

```
# Six Monday/Friday tasks total.
task add "Bootcamp" anchor:"w:mon,fri" chainMax:6 due:today

# Backfill every missed monthly billing occurrence.
task add "Monthly billing" anchor:"m:1" anchor_mode:all due:today

# Stop an existing chain.
task 42 modify chain:off
```

13. Recipe Book

Work and administration

```
# Every weekday at 09:00.
task add "Daily review" anchor:"w:mon..fri@t=09:00"

# First business day of every month.
task add "Open monthly books" anchor:"m:1@nbd@t=09:00" anchor_mode:all

# Last business day of every month.
task add "Close monthly books" anchor:"m:-1bd@t=16:00" anchor_mode:all

# Last Monday of each quarter, moved one business day forward.
```

```
task add "Quarter handoff" anchor:"(w:mon)@in-quarter=last@+1bd"

# Four fixed review dates each year.
task add "Quarterly review" anchor:"y:01-15,04-15,07-15,10-15"
```

Maintenance and follow-ups

```
# Twelve days after each completion.
task add "Mow lawn" cp:12d due:tomorrow+9h

# Escalating follow-up sequence, limited to five links.
task add "Client follow-up" cp:"1d,3d,7d,14d,30d" chainMax:5 due:today

# Variable equipment inspection interval.
task add "Inspect equipment" cp:"rand(10d..14d)" due:today

# Last Friday of every month.
task add "Maintenance window" anchor:"m:last-fri@t=18:00"
```

Personal routines

```
# Monday, Wednesday, and Friday at 07:00.
task add "Workout" anchor:"w:mon,wed,fri@t=07:00"

# One random Saturday each month.
task add "Date night" anchor:"m:rand + w:sat"

# Second Saturday each month.
task add "Deep clean" anchor:"m:2sat"

# Last calendar day of the year at 17:00.
task add "Archive journal" anchor:"y:d-1@t=17:00"
```

Random schedules

```
# One random weekday each week.
task add "Surprise practice" anchor:"w:rand@bd"

# Three distinct random weekdays each month.
task add "Field sampling" anchor:"m:3rand + w:mon..fri"

# One random weekend date each month.
task add "Weekend outing" anchor:"m:rand + w:sat,sun"

# Two random dates drawn only from April, July, or October.
task add "Seasonal audits" anchor:"y:2rand + y:apr,jul,oct"
```

14. Fast Troubleshooting

```
# Read-only installation, configuration, queue, and chain checks.
nautical doctor
```

```
# Include machine-readable findings.
nautical doctor --json

# Show hook diagnostics on stderr for one command.
NAUTICAL_DIAG=1 task add "Nautical test" anchor:"w:mon"
```

Check these first:

- The three hook files are executable.
- `nautical_core/` is installed beside the hooks directory.
- `uda.conf` was added to `~/.taskrc`.
- The task uses either `cp` or anchor recurrence, not both.
- `chainMax`, `chainUntil`, or `chain:off` did not end the chain.
- File-backed dates are inside the configured trusted directory.

Use the [Systems Manual](#) for
repair, reconciliation, sync, queue, and complete configuration guidance.